

The atmosphere

Planet Earth is wrapped in a thin layer of air called the atmosphere. Without this protective blanket of gases, life on Earth could not exist.

Gases in air

Air is a mixture of different gases, including nitrogen, oxygen, and carbon dioxide. Oxygen is vital for plants and animals as it allows them to breathe. Carbon dioxide is vital for plants. They absorb it from the air and use the carbon atoms to help build new leaves and stems.

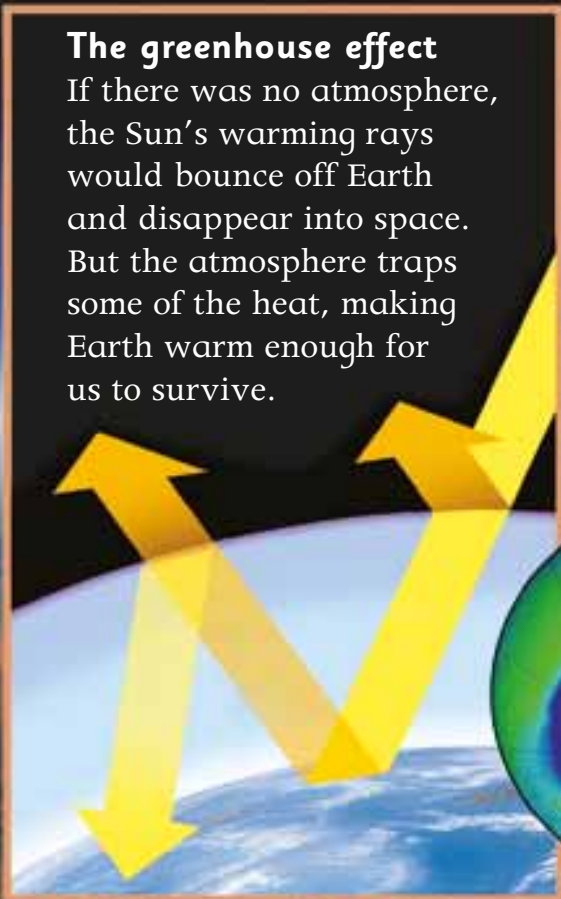


Shimmering particles

The atmosphere is mainly made up of gases, but it also contains tiny particles of dust, pollen, and water droplets. All particles can cause a haze in the air when the Sun shines through them.

The greenhouse effect

If there was no atmosphere, the Sun's warming rays would bounce off Earth and disappear into space. But the atmosphere traps some of the heat, making Earth warm enough for us to survive.



From space, the atmosphere looks like a blue haze over Earth.

Protective layer

A gas called ozone in the atmosphere protects Earth from harmful rays in sunlight. Above Antarctica there is an area of the ozone layer that is much thinner than anywhere else. This "ozone hole" was caused by chemical pollution.

